

CONFUCIAN customs

EDO JAPAN

The military dictatorship that ruled Japan during the Edo period (1603–1868) based their ideology on neo-Confucianism, a philosophy which argued that women should be subservient to men. Attitudes were reflected in maxims designed to teach women moral principles. Educational texts such as the *Onna Daigaku* (Great Learning for Women) embodied the Confucian doctrine: “men superior, women inferior.” However, women continued to hold responsibility within the household, and there were still some ways for them to exercise power.

Confucianism placed heavy emphasis on the importance of respect for one’s elders and ancestors, an idea that became the pillar of a highly stratified society where patriarchal

structures played a crucial role. Heads of household, or *ie*, were generally men. In the past it had been common for a husband to live with his wife’s family, but wives began to live with their husbands’ families instead. In the Edo period, bestowing property on a daughter meant sacrificing part of the family estate, and directly affected women’s inheritance rights.

Buying pleasure

According to Confucian custom, romantic love in marriage was of little importance. Men, therefore, sought it from courtesans. In 17th-century Edo (now Tokyo), prostitution was rife and the government, therefore, established pleasure quarters to control the practice. These walled quarters, known as *yūkaku*, were also founded on the fringes of Kyoto and Osaka, and meant that women of pleasure, *yūjo*, were physically and legally separated from the rest of the city’s female population. In contrast to the *yūjo*, the 1760s brought the rise of the geisha—by and large chaste, she entertained men with music, dance, and conversation. The *okiya* (the lodging house in which geisha live), and the *ochaya* (the teahouse where they work) were operated by women. These *okiya* looked after the geisha, and in return, her earnings went back into the house to pay for non-working geisha and other women in the household. Despite the patriarchal Edo society in which it existed, the world of the geisha itself was, at least theoretically, matriarchal.

◀ Role reversal

The restrictive Edo society forbade women from acting in kabuki theater from 1629, so male performers began to play women on stage, as depicted in this print.



▲ Woman’s kimono

This garment would have been worn by the wife of a merchant. Before the Edo period, the kimono was mainly worn by samurais, but it was adopted by Edo merchants as they gained economic mobility.

